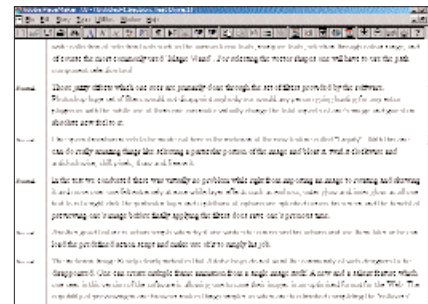


TEST PROCESS

We used a 433 Celeron machine with 192 MB RAM running Windows 2000 as a test bench. We believe Windows 2000/NT is a far more stable OS because of better memory and disk handling, which is a necessity for page layout tools, as they work with large images and other such data.

We tested the page layout software for the following features:

- Memory and hard disk usage
- Features (auto flow, text editing capabilities, creation of tables, various colour modes supported, image editing capabilities)
- Design elements (paragraph style sheets, character style sheets, images, text flow, column guides, frames, layers, masking, text on path, gradient)
- Miscellaneous features (Dictionary, spell check, wizards, templates)
- Ease of use (look and feel, shortcuts, toolbars, help and documentation, tutorials)



Adobe PageMaker Provides a Story Editor to edit text

adjustments to the images while placing elements within the layout of the page. If the software has this capability then it eliminates the need of going back to the image editing software to perform basic editing.

Microsoft Publisher, InDesign, Quark and Frame Maker provide one with basic elements such as rotating, cropping and scaling images, but Adobe PageMaker is particularly impressive because in addition to basic editing capabilities, it also lets the user add Photoshop filter effects. However, these can be added to only TIFF (Tagged Information File Format) images.

Design elements

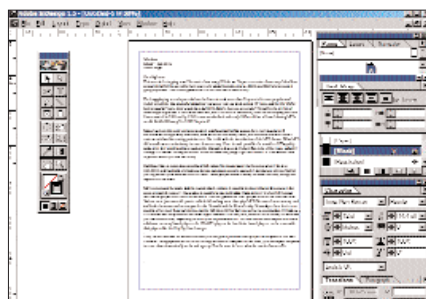
There are certain design elements which layout professionals make use of such as frames, manipulation of layers, masking, column guides, text on path, paragraph and character styles, etc.

Layers: If digital imaging artists can work with layers, then why not page layout professionals? Most software developers have taken this point in consideration and infused functionality into professional page layout software. With the help of multiple layers one can create and edit specific areas in work without disturbing the rest of the areas. For example, if you've placed your text on a specific layer and your images on another, you can temporarily hide the image layer to make proofreading easier.

Only Adobe PageMaker and InDesign provide this functionality wherein one can place different objects on different layers. The layers can be hidden and even locked.

Frames: This element helps in laying out content as it can hold content together (text as well as graphics) and serve the purpose of a placeholder too. Newspapers and magazines use this element as it gives the basic layout structure of the content and one can place empty frames to make it easier to fit in data at a later stage.

Frame Maker, Publisher and InDesign



Extremely intuitive interface of InDesign

explain all the fundamental operations of the software but what they (and also Quark) lack is the look and presentation style which is Adobe PageMaker's forte.

Features

A page layout professional expects certain features—on-the-fly text editing and image editing capabilities, automatic flow of text from one page to another, and the ability to export to different colour modes for pre-press use—to be present in the software. We've emphasised these features and closely examined how the software has bundled them.

Professionals dealing with huge amounts of text find it extremely tedious to manually add and place text on every page. If the software facilitates automatic adding of text, it would make their work much easier. Yet, sometimes when the text has to be flown from one column to another, the user should have the option of flowing text manually.

Adobe PageMaker and InDesign do have the auto flow feature but one will have to first manually add pages, whereas if one is using QuarkXPress, the pages get added automatically. With Publisher it prompts the user to use the auto flow feature and then automatically places the text by adding the pages. Like Quark, Frame Maker automatically puts the text to

another page and does not require the user to add one manually.

At some point of time everybody includes tables in their work. However, it is rare to find a page layout software with a separate program for creating tables. One normally has to create a table in Office suite programs like Excel and place it in the page layout program. The problem here is that the data gets imported without the horizontal and vertical lines. These lines would then need to be drawn manually. Hence it would be better if the software provides the facility of making tables.

Adobe PageMaker does provide the user with a separate program to generate tables but unfortunately one cannot directly import them into PageMaker so one will have to place it as an OLE object. Publisher and Frame Maker have the capability of allowing users to create tables in the software itself but InDesign and Quark do not have this capability. Hence one will have to create tables in a different program and then import them here.

Who does not make mistakes, especially when it comes to typing? Wouldn't it be better if the software provides some easy and quick way of editing the content? Some software enable you to edit text by providing a separate text editor programs whereas others provide on-screen text editing.

Except for Adobe PageMaker, which allows the user the option of editing the text on-screen or editing it in a separate window by selecting Edit Story, the others only allow one to edit the text on-screen.

Though one wouldn't normally use a page layout software for editing images, it would be of great help if the software provided the basic facilities of cropping, rotating and transforming the size of the image as one often finds the need to make some